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COACH V · BUILDING BETTER COACHES

# The Lines Coaches Never Forget

101 things worth saying at practice

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COLLECTED FROM 2,280 COACHES, PLAYERS AND PARENTS  
WHO ANSWERED ONE QUESTION.

None of these are mine.

In July I asked one question online: *what's a line your old coach said that you still catch yourself saying?*

Two thousand two hundred and eighty people answered. Former players in their fifties. Teachers. Parents repeating something to their own kids without meaning to. A woman who still yells "Communication, ladies!" at thirty-three because her volleyball coach did.

What came back wasn't strategy. It was the sentences that outlived the season — the ones that got said so plainly, at exactly the right moment, that they lodged in somebody for twenty years.

These are the hundred and one that stuck hardest. Sourced, sorted by the moment you'd actually reach for them, and handed back to you.

Use the ones that sound like you. Ignore the rest.

— COACH V

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Eight moments. One hundred and one lines.

# 01

## When a kid makes a mistake

The hardest sixty seconds in coaching. These correct without crushing.

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- 01 It's not your fault you missed the fly ball. It's my fault for having you out there in a close game.

A BASEBALL COACH

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- 02 If I wasn't here to tell you, how would you fix this?

- 03 Don't be sorry. Be correct.

A BASKETBALL COACH

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- 04 Make a new mistake.

- 05 Play fast. If you make a mistake, make it at full speed.

- 06 Physical errors happen — I'll never be mad about those. It's the mental errors we can limit.

- 07 It's okay to fail. It's not okay to not try.

- 08 Don't cheat on a test. Fail with honor.

- 09 “But I didn't mean to.” Did you mean not to?

- 10 There's a lot of stuff in life to cry about. Baseball isn't one of them.

- 11 Don't let one moment of stupidity ruin your whole life.

- 12 You're better than that.

WHISPERED, ONCE — NEVER FORGOTTEN

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## 02

# When the effort drops

For the kid who has more in them than they're giving you.

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- 01 Hard work beats talent when talent doesn't work hard.
  - 02 You have a choice: the pain of discipline, or the pain of regret.
  - 03 It doesn't take talent to hustle.
  - 04 You can't teach heart. We may not be the most talented, but nobody is going to outwork us.
  - 05 Don't talk about it. Be about it.
  - 06 If winning was easy, everybody would be doing it.
  - 07 Do what you're supposed to do, not what you want to do.
  - 08 Do what you have to do, so you can do what you want to do.
  - 09 Never accept good enough as good enough.
  - 10 Aim for the top — it's crowded at the bottom.
  - 11 Push yourself today to make it easier tomorrow.
  - 12 If you keep doing what you've been doing, you'll keep getting what you've been getting.
  - 13 Don't tell me. Show me.
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# 03

## At practice

Everything you win in November, you earned in August.

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- 01 What you do in practice is what your body remembers in a game.
  - 02 Practice doesn't make perfect. Practice makes permanent.
  - 03 Don't practice until you get it right. Practice until you can't get it wrong.
  - 04 Amateurs practice so they can get it right. Professionals practice so they can't get it wrong.
  - 05 How you practice is how you perform.  
A BAND DIRECTOR
  - 06 Practice like you're at a meet, so the meet feels like practice.  
A GYMNASTICS COACH
  - 07 Trophies are earned at practice. We go to tournaments to pick them up.
  - 08 You do it right, we do it light. You do it wrong, we do it long.
  - 09 Do it nice, or do it twice.
  - 10 The five P's — proper preparation prevents poor performance.
  - 11 Slow is smooth, and smooth is fast.
  - 12 You don't practice, you don't play.
  - 13 It's easier to stay in shape than it is to get in shape.
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# 04

## Showing up

The standard isn't what you say. It's what you walk past.

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- 01 If you're early, you're on time. If you're on time, you're late.
  - 02 To be early is to be on time. To be on time is to be late. To be late is to be forgotten.
  - 03 If you can't be on time, be early.
  - 04 If you stay ready, you don't have to get ready.
  - 05 If you look good, you feel good, you play good.  
ON DRESSING UP FOR AWAY GAMES
  - 06 Leave it cleaner than you found it.
  - 07 Your maid and your mama don't work here.
  - 08 How we do anything is how we do everything.
  - 09 Your lack of planning does not constitute my emergency.
  - 10 Bad news doesn't get better with age.
  - 11 The best shortcut is doing it right the first time.
  - 12 If you don't have time to do it right, when will you find time to do it again?
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# 05

## When it gets hard

Push, don't punish. Know the difference before you use these.

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01 Are you hurt, or are you injured?

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02 It doesn't hurt. It just feels different.

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03 Power up the hills.

A CROSS COUNTRY COACH

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04 Go over, go under, go around, or go through. But never give up.

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05 You pass out before you die.

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06 Only complain if you're bleeding, throwing up, or passing out.  
Otherwise, get in the water.

A SWIM COACH

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07 Pain is weakness leaving the body.

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08 Rub some dirt on it. You'll be fine.

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09 Rain doesn't make you sick. Germs do.

A CROSS COUNTRY COACH, IN THE RAIN

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10 If you can't outplay them, make sure you can outrun them.

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11 Show them where you live.

BEFORE ANY BIG MATCH

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12 Be the hammer, not the nail.

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13 You didn't finish running. Your teammates are still out there. Go help them.

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# 06

## Character

The part of the job that has nothing to do with the sport.

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01 Integrity is how you conduct yourself when no one is watching.

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02 Don't raise your voice. Improve your argument.

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03 Players play, coaches coach, refs ref. Stay in your lane.

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04 Act like you've been there before.

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05 When you're good, you tell others. When you're great, they'll tell you.

A TENNIS COACH

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06 Never take down a fence until you know why someone put it up.

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07 You don't have to stand on someone else's back to be better.  
Just be better.

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08 Your thoughts control your emotions. Your emotions control your actions. Start with your thoughts.

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09 Follow your heart, but take your brain with you.

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10 Never put yourself in a position to be reliant on anyone but you.

A SINGLE MOM, 1998

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11 Nothing good happens after midnight.

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12 It's a short walk from the castle to the outhouse.

A FOOTBALL COACH, MID-WINNING STREAK

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13 Make everyone better with you.

A SOCCER COACH

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# 07

## The ones they repeat twenty years later

Every line here was sent in by a grown adult who still says it out loud.

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01 Leave it cleaner than you found it.

STILL TEXTED BACK BY FORMER PLAYERS

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02 Power up the hills.

MUTTERED BEFORE HARD DAYS, DECADES ON

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03 Communication, ladies!

STILL YELLED AT THIRTY-THREE

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04 Have a day, boys. Have a day.

A BASEBALL COACH, SAYING GOODBYE

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05 Mobility leads to motility.

A NURSING PROFESSOR, FORTY YEARS AGO

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06 If you hoot with the owls at night, you'd better be ready to soar with the eagles in the morning.

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07 Follow your shot.

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08 Good, better, best. Never let it rest till the good gets better and the better gets best.

A FIFTH-GRADE ENGLISH TEACHER

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09 Writing it down is the same as hearing it seven times.

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10 Winning the game is good. Getting to play it with your friends is better.

A TRAVEL BASKETBALL COACH

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11 Be amazing — but not too amazing. Nobody likes a show-off.

AT DROP-OFF, EVERY MORNING

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12 I love you guys.

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# 08

## The ones that made them laugh

Every coach needs a roast that lands without leaving a mark.

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01 I'm not saying you're slow. You just run too long in the same spot.

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02 I could time you with a calendar.

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03 You don't have to use every cleat on your shoe when you run.

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04 Swing hard. You might hit it.

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05 Is it a 911 or a 411? I'm only taking 911s right now.

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06 This isn't Burger King. You can't have it your way.

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07 Almost only counts in horseshoes and hand grenades.

A GYM TEACHER

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08 Don't sweat petty things, and don't pet sweaty things.

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09 Some days you're the windshield. Some days you're the bug.

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10 If you want to walk, get a dog.

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11 That pain you feel is the Nintendo leaving your body.

FIRST PRACTICE, TEN-YEAR-OLD FOOTBALL

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12 I wish I had ten more like you. Then they'd fire me and I wouldn't have to watch this.

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13 You can't fatten a cow by weighing it.

A PROFESSOR, ON STANDARDIZED TESTING

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# Which one did you keep?

Somebody said one of these to you once and it never left. That's the whole job — you just don't get to know which sentence it'll be.

Say the good ones out loud. Say them often enough that a kid is still repeating them to somebody in 2046.



Reply and tell me what you coach.  
I read every one.